

TargetAI Phase 1 Action Plan

Counselor Credibility Pilot (Months 0-2)

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Executive Summary

This document provides detailed, week-by-week action plans for Phase 1 of TargetAI's go-to-market strategy. The goal is to onboard 10-20 carefully selected independent counselors during the summer months (May-August) to validate product-market fit and build organic credibility within the counseling community.

1. Outreach Strategy

The outreach strategy is founder-led and highly personalized. The goal is quality over quantity—building genuine relationships with counselors who can become long-term advocates.

1.1 Channel Strategy

Primary Channels (70% of effort)

LinkedIn Direct Outreach

- Target: Independent Educational Consultants (IECs) with 500+ connections
- Look for: IECA members, former admissions officers, counselors with active content
- Approach: Connect first, engage with their content for 1-2 weeks, then personalized message
- Expected response rate: 15-25% with warm approach

Professional Association Networks

- IECA (Independent Educational Consultants Association) - Primary target
- HECA (Higher Education Consultants Association) - Secondary target
- NACAC regional affiliates - for geographic diversity
- Strategy: Attend virtual events, participate in forums, identify thought leaders

Secondary Channels (30% of effort)

Warm Introductions

- Leverage StemPro Academy existing network
- Ask early adopters for 2-3 referrals each
- Target: Counselors they respect but who aren't direct competitors

Content-Based Attraction

- Publish 2-3 thought leadership pieces on LinkedIn about AI in counseling
- Focus on ethical AI use—align with TargetAI positioning
- Include soft CTA: "DM me if you'd like early access to what we're building"

1.2 Messaging Framework

Initial Connection Message (LinkedIn)

Hi [Name],

I've been following your work on [specific post/topic]. Your perspective on [specific insight] really resonated with me.

I'm building a counselor-first AI platform at StemPro Academy—designed to amplify your expertise, not replace it. No AI essay writing. No acceptance guarantees. Just intelligent tools that save you time on admin so you can focus on what matters.

Would you be open to a 20-minute call? I'd love your perspective—even if it's just to tell me what we're getting wrong.

— [Your name]

Follow-Up Message (After Demo Interest)

Thanks for your interest, [Name]!

Quick context: We're in private pilot mode with just 10-15 counselors. The goal is to get this right before going broader—your feedback will directly shape the product.

Pilot includes: Full platform access, priority support, and a founding member rate locked in forever.

Here's my calendar: [link]. Pick any time that works.

1.3 Weekly Outreach Cadence

Week	Outreach Volume	Focus Activities	Target Outcome
1-2	20 connections/week	LinkedIn profile optimization, initial connects	40 new connections
3-4	15 DMs/week	Personalized outreach to engaged connections	8-10 demo calls scheduled
5-6	10 DMs/week + referral asks	Demos, onboarding, referral requests	5-8 pilots started, 10+ referrals
7-8	Referral-focused	Support existing pilots, pursue referrals	10-15 total active pilots

2. Pilot Counselor Selection Criteria

Not all counselors are equal for a pilot. The right mix ensures diverse feedback, strong advocacy potential, and representative use cases.

2.1 Must-Have Criteria

Every pilot counselor should meet ALL of these requirements:

1. **Active Caseload:** Currently working with 10+ students annually. This ensures they have real workflow needs and can stress-test the platform.
2. **Tech Comfort:** Already uses digital tools (CRM, Zoom, Google Workspace). Not looking to convert tech-resistant counselors in pilot phase.
3. **Independent or Small Firm:** Solo practitioners or firms with <5 counselors. Large organizations have slower decision cycles and complex procurement.
4. **Ethical Alignment:** Values integrity in the admissions process. Red flag: counselors who promise outcomes or use aggressive marketing.
5. **Feedback Willingness:** Explicitly agrees to provide structured feedback (bi-weekly check-ins, NPS survey, exit interview).

2.2 Preferred Attributes (Aim for Diversity)

Build a pilot cohort that represents different use cases:

Attribute	Target Mix	Why It Matters
Experience Level	5 newer (<5 yrs), 10 veteran (5+ yrs)	Different workflow needs and tech expectations
Geographic Region	Mix of coasts, midwest, south	Regional differences in college prep culture
Student Demographics	Mix: affluent, middle-income, scholarship-focused	Tests platform across different use cases
Specialization	General IECs + 3-4 specialists (STEM, arts, athletes)	Validates niche applicability
Social Presence	At least 5 with 1,000+ LinkedIn followers	Potential advocates with reach

2.3 Red Flags (Disqualifiers)

Do NOT onboard counselors who:

- Make outcome guarantees ("Get into your dream school!")
- Have negative industry reputation or ethical complaints
- Are direct competitors building similar tools
- Won't commit to feedback schedule (too busy = not a good pilot fit)
- Express hostility toward AI in counseling (not skepticism—hostility)

2.4 Scoring Rubric

Use this scorecard during initial calls to qualify candidates:

Criterion	1 pt	2 pts	3 pts	Notes
Active caseload size	10-20	20-40	40+	
Current tech stack sophistication	Basic	Moderate	Advanced	
Feedback commitment level	Monthly	Bi-weekly	Weekly	
Industry influence/reach	Low	Medium	High	
Ethical alignment signals	Unclear	Aligned	Champion	

Minimum score to proceed: 8/15. Prioritize candidates scoring 12+ for first wave.

3. Onboarding & Demo Process

A structured onboarding process ensures counselors reach value quickly and stay engaged throughout the pilot.

3.1 Onboarding Timeline Overview

Phase	Duration	Key Activities
Discovery Call	20-30 minutes	Qualify fit, understand workflow, gauge interest
Demo Session	45-60 minutes	Full platform walkthrough, Q&A, pilot agreement
Hands-on Setup	30-45 minutes	Account creation, first student import, quick wins
Week 1 Check-in	15-20 minutes	Troubleshoot issues, answer questions, gather feedback
Bi-weekly Syncs	15 minutes ongoing	Progress check, feature feedback, NPS pulse

3.2 Discovery Call Script

Purpose: Qualify the counselor and understand their specific needs before investing in a full demo.

Opening (2 min)

"Thanks for taking the time, [Name]. Before I tell you about what we're building, I'd love to understand your practice better. This helps me know if we'd actually be useful to you—I'd rather be honest upfront than waste your time."

Discovery Questions (10-15 min)

1. "Walk me through a typical week during peak season. Where do you spend most of your time?"
2. "What tools do you currently use to manage students and track applications?"
3. "How do you currently handle meeting notes and follow-ups?"
4. "What's your biggest pain point—the thing that makes you think 'there has to be a better way'?"
5. "How do you feel about AI in counseling? What excites you or concerns you?"

Brief Pitch (5 min)

"Based on what you've shared, here's where I think TargetAI could help: [customize to their pain points]. We're specifically built for counselors—not students, not parents. The AI assists you; it doesn't replace your judgment. And we have a hard rule: no AI essay writing, no acceptance guarantees."

Close & Next Steps (3 min)

"I'd love to show you the platform in action. I can do a 45-minute demo where you'll see exactly how this works with your workflow. Would [date/time] work for you?"

3.3 Demo Session Structure

Duration: 45-60 minutes

Demo Flow:

Time	Section	Details
0-5 min	Reconnect & Agenda	Recap pain points from discovery call, set expectations
5-15 min	Student Management Demo	Show dashboard, add student flow, profile completion tracking
15-25 min	AI Features Showcase	AI chat assistant, meeting reports, college gap analysis
25-35 min	Essay & College Tools	Essay positioning map, college list builder, compare students
35-45 min	Q&A + Pilot Discussion	Answer questions, discuss pilot terms, secure commitment
45-60 min	(Optional) Live Setup	If ready to commit, begin hands-on setup immediately

3.4 Hands-On Setup Session

Goal: Get the counselor to "first value" within this session—they should leave with a real student in the system and one AI-generated insight.

Setup Checklist:

- **Account Creation** (5 min) - Create counselor account, set preferences
- **First Student Import** (10 min) - Add 1-2 real students (with consent) or demo students
- **Profile Completion** (10 min) - Fill in key profile sections for one student
- **AI Quick Win** (10 min) - Generate a profile summary or college suggestions using AI chat
- **Schedule First Meeting** (5 min) - Create a meeting in the system to test meeting features

3.5 Ongoing Support Structure

Support Type	Frequency	Format
Bi-weekly check-in	Every 2 weeks	15-min video call or async Loom
Slack/Email support	Ongoing	Response within 4 hours during business days
Bug/feedback submission	As needed	In-app feedback button or direct message
Feature request review	Monthly	Compiled list shared with pilot cohort
NPS survey	Week 4 and Week 8	Simple 1-question survey + optional comments

3.6 Pilot Agreement Terms

What the counselor agrees to:

- Use TargetAI with at least 5 students during the pilot period
- Participate in bi-weekly check-in calls (15 minutes)
- Complete NPS surveys at Week 4 and Week 8

- Provide honest feedback on bugs, UX issues, and feature requests
- Keep platform details confidential during private pilot

What TargetAI provides:

- Free access during pilot period (8 weeks)
- Founding member pricing locked in: 50% off standard rates, forever
- Priority support with direct founder access
- Early access to new features
- Recognition as a founding partner (optional, with consent)

Appendix: Weekly Execution Checklist

Week 1-2: Foundation

1. Optimize LinkedIn profile with counselor-focused positioning
2. Build target list of 50 counselors matching selection criteria
3. Send 20 connection requests with personalized notes
4. Engage with 10 counselor posts (meaningful comments, not generic)
5. Draft and publish first LinkedIn thought leadership post
6. Prepare demo environment with realistic sample data

Week 3-4: Active Outreach

1. Send 15 personalized DMs to engaged connections
2. Schedule 8-10 discovery calls
3. Conduct discovery calls using provided script
4. Score candidates using rubric
5. Convert qualified leads to demo sessions
6. Publish second thought leadership post

Week 5-6: Conversion & Onboarding

1. Conduct demo sessions for qualified candidates
2. Complete hands-on setup for committed pilots
3. Execute Week 1 check-in calls with new pilots
4. Ask each pilot for 2-3 referrals
5. Document feedback and feature requests
6. Continue outreach via referrals

Week 7-8: Scale & Validate

1. Reach 10-15 active pilot counselors
2. Conduct bi-weekly check-ins with all pilots
3. Deploy Week 4 NPS survey
4. Analyze feedback themes and prioritize fixes
5. Identify 3-5 potential advocate counselors
6. Begin Phase 2 planning with validated learnings

Success Metrics Summary

Metric	Target	Measurement Method
Pilot counselors onboarded	10-15	CRM tracking
Net Promoter Score	≥ 8 (promoter threshold)	NPS survey at Week 4 & 8
Weekly active usage	≥ 70% of pilots	Platform analytics
Referrals generated	10+ qualified referrals	Referral tracking
Feature feedback items	30+ actionable items	Feedback log
Positioning language validated	3+ resonant phrases	Qualitative interviews

— *End of Document* —
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